

Network Printers are on an average costlier than other laser printers as they are targeted at the corporate segment

Michael Browne

Many homes and small offices have made the transition from inkjet to laser because of the costs of consumables involved with inkjets. Laser printers are more versatile and are faster. Add to that the fact that a toner cartridge can output some 5,000 (if not more) pages of text, and the laser printer makes one sweet buy if your printing needs are heavy.

If you have more than one PC at home, or if you have a small office with just one printer, you can easily configure it to be used by multiple systems. We get down to assist you setting up your laser printer on a network.

Network And Non-Network Printers

As far as networking and printers go, there are two types of laser printers—network-enabled printers, and non-network printers. Almost all the printers manufactured in the last two years are network-enabled, meaning they can be directly plugged into a TCP/IP network. These printers can be assigned an IP address, and any machine accessing them on a network can print to them. Network-enabled printers are more expensive, but are worth it considering that no print server is required; the configuration is much easier. An ordinary laser printer (meaning non-network) needs a print server to be installed, with the printer being assigned a virtual port. Here are the steps involved.

Steps for a Network Printer

1. Connect your printer to the LAN (RJ45) cable. Power it on. Now there are two ways to set up a network printer. The first is by

using the menu on your printer. Network printers come with LCD screens, which can be used to configure all aspects of the printer. Navigate to the main menu. Note that your printer needs paper in the In tray before you can use the menu.

2. Get into the Network menu using the arrow keys, and select Yes in the Network Configuration option. Go to "Get Network Address" and select Manual. You will be using the directional keys a lot now.

3. You will get a blank screen, where you assign a unique IP address to the printer. Your IP address should look something like 128.128.135.28—this number is an example. Note that this is a Static IP—an IP that, once assigned, will not change unless manually changed.

4. The next step involves entering an SM (Subnet Mask) number, which will be something like 255.255.0.0. There are some advanced options as well—mostly Yes and No options—but there's no need to configure anything.

5. Now install the drivers on one PC on the network. Note that since the printer is not shared through one PC, you will have to individually install the drivers on each PC that needs access to the printer.

6. The drivers, when installed, will give you a Toolbox/Setup window, where you have to assign a printer port to the printer, as in the next step. Note that the software will search the network for all printers by that manufacturer: for example, HP printing software will only search for HP laser printers on the network, and list them.

7. Once the printer has been located, it's simply a matter of assigning the printer a port on

your machine, which can be done using the drivers.

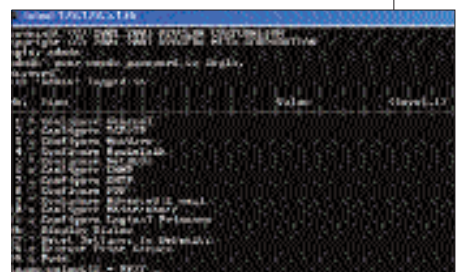
In the rare event that your network printer doesn't have an LCD display—meaning you can't set it up from the printer controls itself—the software kit accompanying it will definitely have the necessary tools to assign an IP to the printer.

As far as operating system dependency goes, users of Windows 98/98SE will need to install LPR (Line Printer Remote), which is an optional install component available on the Windows CD, but which doesn't install by default. LPR is a spool command and not a printer command; it simply spools files to a location for print.

Under Windows 2000 and all its flavours, the TCP/IP configuration under Network Components will have to be installed. Windows XP installs these options by default, so your task is simplified.

Using Telnet

A network printer can also be configured using the "telnet" command. If you do not know your printer's IP address, set it to the factory defaults. All network laser printers have a small button that resets everything to



A typical telnet window

its default values. This button is typically located on the rear of the printer, and may sit inside a recess to prevent accidental setting of the switch.





**PRESENTING THE
SMARTER WAY TO FLY.**